SREENIDHI MODEL UNITED NATIONS

SMUN 2026 | COMMITTEE BACKGROUND GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL

UNSC

United Nations Security Council

COMMITTEE AGENDA

Deliberating on the Escalation of Tensions between Iran and Gulf States, with Emphasis on the Strait of Hormuz, Proxy Conflicts, and Emerging Non-Traditional Warfare

Diplomacy • Maritime Security • Regional Stability

Message from the Secretariat

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026. The Secretariat is pleased to welcome you to the United Nations Security Council, where you will deliberate upon the escalation of tensions between Iran and the Gulf States, with particular emphasis on the Strait of Hormuz, proxy conflicts and emerging non-traditional warfare.

The agenda brings together questions of collective security, state sovereignty, the law of the sea, diplomacy and the protection of civilian life. A maritime incident, disputed cyber operation or escalation involving an armed non-state actor may have implications that extend well beyond the immediate region. The Council must therefore consider how to prevent miscalculation and preserve avenues for peaceful settlement.

This Background Guide introduces the Council's mandate and examines the history, international legal principles and contemporary security challenges relevant to the agenda. It outlines possible diplomatic and institutional responses, but is intended as a foundation for further independent research rather than a substitute for studying the documented position of your assigned Member State.

We encourage delegates to distinguish verified facts from contested allegations, consider the differing interests of individual Gulf States and evaluate the legal authority, feasibility and consequences of every proposed measure. Effective diplomacy requires principled argument, responsible negotiation and a clear understanding of the responsibilities entrusted to the Security Council.

We look forward to thoughtful debate, constructive engagement and resolutions that reflect the seriousness of the issues before you.

Warm regards,
The Secretariat
Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026

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A guide to careful diplomacy, maritime security and the peaceful settlement of international disputes.

01 Introduction to the Committee

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is a principal organ of the United Nations entrusted under Article 24 of the UN Charter with primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security. Unlike bodies whose principal function is to deliberate or recommend, the Security Council may, within its Charter powers, adopt decisions that Member States are obliged to carry out. Its institutional design therefore combines diplomacy, legal authority and significant political responsibility.

The Council comprises fifteen members: five permanent members (China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom and the United States) and ten elected members serving two-year terms. Each member holds one vote. Under Article 27, substantive decisions generally require nine affirmative votes and the concurring votes of the permanent members, subject to the Charter's voting rules. The possibility of a veto profoundly affects negotiations and the formulation of politically viable resolutions.

Mandate, powers and instruments

Chapter VI of the Charter prioritises peaceful settlement, including negotiation, mediation, enquiry, conciliation and other agreed methods. Under Chapter VII, the Council may determine the existence of a threat to the peace, breach of the peace or act of aggression, and may adopt measures ranging from sanctions and other non-force measures under Article 41 to authorised action under Article 42. These powers are neither interchangeable nor automatic: their use requires careful attention to the factual circumstances, legal basis, proportionality of the response and likely humanitarian consequences.

The Council can convene urgent meetings, request briefings, encourage mediation, issue presidential statements, establish monitoring and sanctions arrangements where authorised, and seek reports on implementation. Its authority does not remove the need for sustained regional diplomacy or the cooperation of affected states and relevant international organisations.

Why this agenda belongs before the Council

Escalating confrontation between Iran and neighbouring Gulf States potentially implicates the safety of civilian populations, the use of force, maritime navigation, regional stability and the security of global commerce. The multiplicity of state and non-state actors, together with uncertainty surrounding attribution of attacks, makes this agenda particularly suited to the Council's preventive diplomacy and crisis-management functions. Delegates should seek outcomes that are legally defensible, realistic in implementation and acceptable to a sufficiently broad coalition of Council members.

02 Introduction to the Agenda

The agenda concerns the risk of escalation arising from strategic competition, maritime incidents, indirect military confrontation and increasingly sophisticated methods of warfare in and around the Persian Gulf. It requires a distinction between enduring regional disagreements and particular incidents that may demand an immediate international response. It also requires recognition that Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and Oman maintain distinct diplomatic relationships, economic priorities and security calculations in respect of Iran; the Gulf States should not be treated as a single undifferentiated bloc.

The Strait of Hormuz lies between Iran and Oman and links the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and onward maritime routes. Its significance is both regional and global: a threat to commercial vessels, ports or energy infrastructure can affect seafarer safety, insurance, trade, energy supply chains and the economic interests of states far beyond the region. Heightened military activity may also produce cycles of misperception in which measures perceived as defensive by one state are interpreted as escalatory by another.

Contemporary confrontation is not confined to conventional engagements between armed forces. Cyber intrusions, unmanned aerial systems, electronic interference, information operations and attacks involving armed non-state groups can produce serious effects without immediately revealing who directed or controlled an operation. Effective deliberation must therefore consider both the prevention of incidents and credible procedures for assessing responsibility after they occur.

> *"In a conflict, one party can always claim victory, but building peace must involve everybody."*
> *— Martti Ahtisaari, Nobel Peace Prize laureate (2008)*

The central diplomatic question is how states can address legitimate security concerns, uphold applicable international law and preserve open channels of communication without normalising attacks on civilian infrastructure or unintentionally intensifying regional polarisation.

03 Explanation of the Agenda

3.1 Historical Context: Evolution of Iran–Gulf Relations

Relations between Iran and the states bordering the Persian Gulf have long been shaped by geography, maritime commerce, competing political interests and strategic relationships with powers outside the region. The 1979 Iranian Revolution transformed Iran's foreign relations, while the Iran–Iraq War of 1980–1988 and associated attacks on commercial shipping demonstrated how regional conflicts could threaten international maritime trade. The 1990–1991 Gulf crisis and later regional interventions further influenced Gulf security arrangements.

Over subsequent decades, differences concerning regional influence, security alliances, missile capabilities and armed groups contributed to periods of heightened tension. At the same time, diplomatic engagement has remained possible: regional states have pursued dialogue, economic ties and, in some instances, the restoration of diplomatic relations. These developments illustrate why the Gulf States should not be approached as a single political actor with uniform priorities.

For the Security Council, historical context is essential to evaluating current risks without treating every maritime incident or confrontation as an isolated event. Effective preventive diplomacy must account for long-standing perceptions of insecurity as well as opportunities for confidence-building and regional dialogue.

3.2 Current Regional Challenges and Diverging National Interests

Iran–Gulf relations have been influenced by competition over regional influence, contrasting security partnerships, ideological and political differences, maritime interests and developments in neighbouring conflicts. Nevertheless, these factors do not determine an inevitable path towards confrontation. Diplomatic engagement, economic interdependence and regional dialogue can coexist with substantial security disagreements. Delegates should distinguish the positions of individual governments and examine how domestic priorities and external alliances affect the feasibility of multilateral arrangements.

A durable proposal should identify the immediate conduct to be prevented, the parties whose cooperation is needed and the incentives that could sustain de-escalation. Possible confidence-building measures include direct military-to-military communication, incident notification procedures, maritime hotlines and agreed channels for emergency diplomatic engagement.

3.3 Strait of Hormuz: Maritime Security and Navigation

The Strait of Hormuz is a strategically sensitive waterway used by commercial and naval vessels. Maritime incidents may involve vessel interdiction, threats or attacks against shipping, navigational interference, and the close proximity of military forces. A single incident can have economic consequences disproportionate to its immediate physical scale and may trigger demands for rapid retaliation.

The legal analysis requires care. The 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) addresses navigation through straits used for international navigation, including the regime of transit passage where applicable. States' treaty positions and relevant customary international law must be assessed rather than assuming that identical treaty obligations apply to all parties. The Charter's rules concerning the threat or use of force also remain relevant. The safety of civilian mariners and the protection of commercial navigation should remain central to Council deliberations.

Useful proposals may address real-time incident communication, independent fact-finding where feasible, cooperation with maritime authorities, and the avoidance of threatening manoeuvres. Such mechanisms require clarity about participation, information confidentiality, reporting lines and how disputes over alleged incidents would be handled.

3.4 Proxy Conflicts and Armed Non-State Actors

Regional violence may involve armed groups whose relationships with outside states differ considerably in their degree of support, coordination and control. The expression "proxy conflict" is therefore a starting point for analysis, not a substitute for evidence. Claims concerning sponsorship, command or legal responsibility should be assessed separately and on the basis of credible information.

Indirect confrontation is difficult to resolve because local actors have their own objectives and incentives, while external governments may perceive different security costs in compromise. Delegates should examine ceasefire support, prevention of cross-border attacks, restrictions on weapons transfers where legally warranted, and the possibilities for inclusive political dialogue. Any proposal must account for the relevant conflict setting and applicable rules of international humanitarian law.

3.5 Cyber Operations, Drones and Non-Traditional Threats

Cyber operations against ports, energy facilities, telecommunications or financial systems can affect vital civilian services. Unmanned aerial vehicles and other remotely operated systems may enable attacks at a distance, while electronic interference and disinformation can complicate verification, public understanding and crisis response. These methods may create ambiguity as to the origin, scale and intended effects of an incident.

Delegates should consider safeguards against misattribution, secure channels for technical exchange, protection of critical civilian infrastructure, and mechanisms for reporting potentially escalatory

incidents. International law, including the UN Charter and other applicable rules, remains relevant to state conduct involving new technologies; however, legal classification depends on the circumstances and effects of each operation.

3.6 Energy Security and Humanitarian Consequences

Disruptions to navigation or energy installations can have consequences for global supply chains, shipping costs and energy-dependent economies. The security of energy infrastructure must be considered alongside risks to workers, coastal communities, commercial crews and civilian populations affected by regional hostilities. Responses that focus exclusively on military deterrence may overlook the cumulative humanitarian and economic effects of prolonged uncertainty.

Delegates should assess proportionate contingency planning, protection of civilian infrastructure, maritime safety arrangements and coordination with competent international and regional bodies. Where sanctions or other coercive measures are contemplated, their intended targets, monitoring requirements and potential humanitarian impact should be examined.

3.7 International Legal and Institutional Frameworks

Legal authority and institutional competence must not be conflated. The UNSC may mandate or recommend particular measures within its powers, but their implementation may depend on Member States, relevant organisations, regional counterparts and available resources.

3.8 Current International Responses and the Role of the Security Council

The international response to security crises in the Gulf involves multiple institutions and diplomatic channels. The Security Council may call for restraint, request reporting and briefings, support mediation, recommend peaceful settlement and, where the relevant legal conditions are satisfied, determine measures under Chapter VII of the UN Charter. Each form of action raises questions concerning the Council's authority, political feasibility, proportionality and implementation.

International maritime and diplomatic cooperation may also involve the International Maritime Organization, relevant coastal and flag States, regional organisations and technical authorities responsible for maritime safety. United Nations bodies and processes addressing cyber security and responsible state behaviour provide a wider framework for risk reduction, but their guidance should not be confused with binding Council measures or established treaty obligations.

Responses to reported attacks, cyber operations or support for armed groups must distinguish independently corroborated information from allegations and contested attribution. Delegates should therefore consider transparent incident-reporting procedures, crisis communications, maritime safety coordination, protection of civilian infrastructure and practical confidence-building arrangements that can be accepted across political differences.

3.9 A Realistic Path Towards De-escalation

A constructive Council response could follow a staged approach: immediate restraint and verified incident reporting; protected diplomatic and military communication channels; maritime safety and infrastructure safeguards; support for negotiation over disputed issues; and periodic review of the measures agreed. The viability of each stage depends on the consent or cooperation of the relevant parties, available institutional capacity and a clear method of determining whether commitments are being respected.

"Peace is more precious than diamonds or silver or gold." — Martin Luther King Jr., Nobel Peace Prize laureate (1964)

For debate purposes, proposals should distinguish preventive measures from enforcement action, specify who would implement them and identify the legal and diplomatic consequences of non-compliance. Delegates should avoid treating unverified allegations as established facts, particularly when discussing cyberattacks, maritime incidents or the actions of armed groups.

04 Reference Links and Resources

The following sources are retained from the original UNSC background document. Delegates should prioritise official texts when researching legal obligations or Council decisions and verify the date and original context of all reports.

01. United Nations Security Council

Council membership, meetings, resolutions, official statements and institutional mandate.

02. United Nations Charter — Chapter VII

The Council's powers concerning threats to peace, enforcement measures and related procedures.

03. United Nations Secretary-General

Official statements, briefings and diplomatic initiatives concerning international crises.

04. International Maritime Organization

Maritime safety, commercial shipping, seafarer protection and international cooperation.

05. United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea

The international legal framework on maritime zones and navigation, including applicable passage regimes.

06. Reuters

Contemporary reporting on regional diplomacy, security incidents, energy markets and maritime developments.

07. International Crisis Group

Regional conflict analysis, diplomatic initiatives and possible approaches to de-escalation.

08. International Institute for Strategic Studies

Research on regional security, defence policies and strategic developments.

09. United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs

Arms control, international security and emerging technological risks.

10. United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism

UN work on counter-terrorism cooperation and related international frameworks.

11. United Nations Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies

UN initiatives on digital governance and emerging technologies.

05 Questions to Consider

The following questions are intended to guide country research, moderated debate and the drafting of practicable Security Council outcomes. Delegates should support their positions with official statements, applicable legal instruments and verifiable evidence.

01. How have Iran's relationships with individual Gulf States evolved, and which differences between those states matter most for collective diplomatic action?

02. What types of incidents in the Strait of Hormuz pose the greatest risk of escalation, and what concrete maritime confidence-building measures could reduce that risk?

03. How do the applicable law of the sea and the UN Charter govern navigation, coastal-state conduct and threats or uses of force in this setting?

04. How can the Council assess contested allegations about attacks on vessels, infrastructure or military assets without prejudging responsibility?

05. Which mechanisms could prevent misunderstandings between military forces operating in close proximity?

06. What is the appropriate approach to armed non-state actors and alleged external support when the degree of state control remains disputed?

07. How might ceasefire support, regional diplomacy and political negotiations address the drivers of indirect conflict?

08. What arrangements could improve cooperation against cyber operations, drone attacks and threats to critical civilian infrastructure?

09. How can measures protecting international shipping also respect state sovereignty and reduce the risk of militarisation?

10. What are the likely economic and humanitarian consequences of prolonged disruption to Gulf maritime trade and energy infrastructure?

11. Under what circumstances should the UNSC rely on Chapter VI diplomacy rather than consider Chapter VII measures, and what safeguards should accompany either approach?

12. How might permanent-member positions and the veto affect the negotiation and adoption of a Council response?

13. Which regional governments, organisations and technical agencies would be essential to implementing an agreed response?

14. How should the Council structure reporting, monitoring and periodic review so that de-escalation measures can be assessed objectively?

15. What would a balanced, legally supportable and politically achievable resolution look like from the perspective of the delegate's assigned country?